

Troubleshoot a buggy system... Like a boss

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We've all faced that dreaded moment when we try to turn on our computer and either it doesn't start at all or stops functioning unexpectedly. At this point we feel frus-

different approaches and so this guide won't try to spoon-feed you, but will provide pointers in the right direction.

Here we present a top down organized checklist to guide you in troubleshooting. We'll be using the Worst to Best Case Scenario Methodology for diagnosing of the issues in this workshop. This means we'll start with

the Worst Case of your computer not starting at all to the Best Case where it requires a minor tweak, and all the steps in between. Identify how broken your computer is, and start fixing. A word of advice: even if you're not facing the Worst Case Scenario [the problem], it's strongly recommended to run through the checklist as the problem might be a result of something mentioned in the previous steps.

The guide will apply for both laptops and desktops and either of Windows or Linux operating systems.

Checklist

The first thing to do when faced with a malfunctioning system is to calm down; panic won't help. To reassure you a bit, there is over a 90 per-cent chance that your data is still safe; it's just not accessible to you, right now. Often it might simply be a simple issue of loose connections or an inexpensive piece of broken hardware or a wrong setting. Let's begin with the worst case scenario.

Your computer doesn't turn on at all

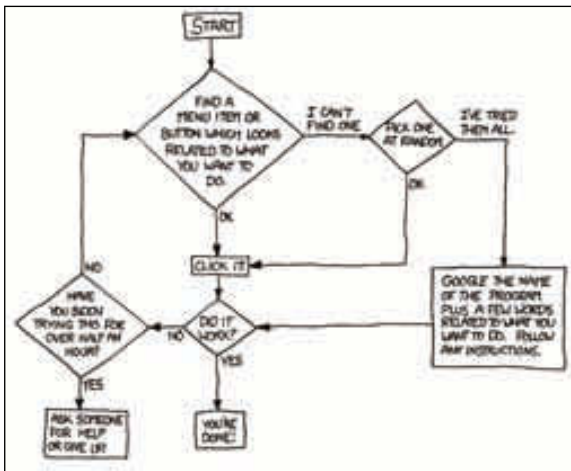
1. Check the basics: Sounds silly but is your power on? Is the display up? Look for any LED activity lights

(power, hard disk, network) and listen for any spinning noises of fan and hard disk. If there are no signs of life then perform the following checks or else skip to the next step.

2. In case of desktop check if the main powers cord is attached to the wall, the switch is on, and also if there is power supply in the socket, try putting some other appliance in there.
3. For laptops ensure your battery is charged, and the laptop is connected to a charger. Try putting in another battery if you have access to the same or one from a similar model.
4. Check if the reset switch on the front panel from your case is stuck. You can check that by pressing it. If you can't move it, that means it's stuck, and you need to release it using a small screwdriver. In the worst case you'll need to replace it.
5. If you're on a desktop, try reconnecting all the cables and do a bit of dusting. You won't believe the number of systems that turn on simply by reassembling and cleaning off all the dust. If at this point it's still not turning on, it's likely that your SMPS has conked off. You'll need to replace it with new one.

System turns on, but absolutely no display or switches off immediately

1. Ensure that your monitor is plugged in and switched on and is working properly. Try connecting your monitor to another device if possible.
2. With laptops you're a little out of luck. The error might not be only with the display panel but also the cable that powers it or the graphics card (if nothing at all is displayed) a graphics card error is rare.
3. Don't worry, all is not lost yet; you would have noticed your computer beeps once when you boot it,



A comical yet almost true approach to system troubleshooting

trated and exasperated, and many of us are clueless as to what to do next. Fret not, this workshop will equip you with many Do-It-Yourself solutions for fixing a crashed or a malfunctioning computer. All you need is basic computer knowledge, some tools, a little patience and a can of Red Bull. As with anything to do with PC repair, you need to try



Advanced system settings